

# FORGING CHENNAI'S ESPORTS FUTURE

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**W**hen Skyesports cancelled its third tournament of the year, Skyesports Masters 2025, online communities wondered what was next for one of India's leading esports organisers. Days later, Skyesports had its answer: the inaugural edition of Chennai Esports Global Championship (CEGC) between November 7-16, with support from the Government of Tamil Nadu.

"After the VRS (Valve Regional Standings) rankings, the calendar was structured (in a way that companies like ESL and Blast put in a lot of money into bringing in major teams, focusing on the Tier 1 ecosystem," Shiva Nandy (right), the founder and CEO of Skyesports, tells *Sportstar*.

"But for Counter-Strike or Dota 2, the Tier 2, Tier 3 tournaments are lagging. So, we thought of restructuring — bridging the gap between Tier 2,3 and Tier 1."

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"We are expecting over 100 teams each from Europe, Southeast Asia and India. Big teams like Eternal Fire and OG have already registered, and if everything goes well, S1mple might come to Chennai," Nandy adds.



Oleksandr 'S1mple' Kostyliiev (right) is a CS Major and Intel Grand Slam champion and one of the most decorated CS players of all time. His presence will naturally raise CEGC's stakes, both in terms of competition and engagement.

But for Skyesports, CEGC is a step towards a broader goal.

"When I was 10 years old, my parents didn't (always) encourage me to play cricket. Now, my wife takes my kids to the CSK (Chennai Super Kings Academy). We see a similar future for esports in India," Nandy says.

A parallel between cricket and video games would have attracted amusement 20 years ago. Not anymore. The Union Government, World Anti-Doping Agency, International Olympic Committee and Olympic Council of Asia have acknowledged esports as a legitimate sport, one making inroads to become a potent career option.

"Maybe four to five years ago, there wasn't a lot of Indian (esports) representation on the global stage," Sriram Vishaal, the company's Head of Esports, says.

"Now we are seeing it from different titles: India returned to PMGC [PUBG Mobile Global Championship] (in 2025 after four years) and GodLike (esports team) coming second in the World Championship (2023).

"The India Game Developer Conference, CEGC, and (esports in) CM Trophy are happening in Chennai. Things are changing."

